EXPLORING THE "HUMAN NORM" IN DESIGN: INTEGRATING MORE-THAN-HUMAN AND NORM-CRITICAL DESIGN APPROACHES

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ABSTRACT

As designers, we design from a human perspective —a position we cannot change but must critically reflect upon. This workshop addresses this fundamental challenge: the invisible "human norm" in design. While norm-critical approaches have explored norms, the most profound invisible norm is simply our existence as humans. This is particularly significant as we confront environmental crises demanding design beyond human needs. We integrate two complementary approaches: more-than-human design, which challenges the assumption that "human-centeredness" represents a neutral viewpoint, and norm-critical design, which makes invisible norms visible. Our 3-hour workshop engages participants in interactive activities analyzing human norms, shifting perspectives, creating norm-critical prototypes, and sharing reflections. We contribute to design research by offering a novel methodological framework combining these previously separate approaches and providing the crucial first step toward addressing needs beyond humans: making human norms in design visible and subject to critical examination.

WORKSHOP DESCRIPTION

In the following, we describe the direction of the exploration, its significance and relevance for design as well as the research basis for the workshop.

DIRECTION OF THE EXPLORATION

As designers, we need to be aware of our own positionality (Cerná et al., 2021) as it has a significant impact on our design work. This is not so much a matter of not producing "biased work" but understanding ourselves and which norms, assumptions and perspectives we are basing our decisions on. When we design, we ultimately design from a human perspective. Though this is not something we can change, it is something we need to be critically aware of: as humans, we design from a specific position that inherently shapes our designs and the possible relations we create (Light, 2024). Recently, a rich array of approaches—sometimes grouped under the umbrella term "morethan-human design" (Rosén et al.,2024)—have emerged to challenge the assumption that "human-centeredness" represents a neutral or universal viewpoint (Braidotti, 2021). These frameworks help us recognize and reflect on the particular position from which we are designing. But mainly, they highlight the need for a deeper self-



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awareness of human norms and biases in our design work by making them visible (Cerna et al., 2024).

SIGNIFICANCE AND RELEVANCE

We want to contribute to this emerging body of literature by integrating two complementary approaches that will help us achieve reflection on the "human norm" in our design work: more-than-human design and normcritical design. When we design, we follow norms that remain largely invisible to us. This phenomenon has been extensively explored in relation to gender norms and other social constructs. Yet one of the most invisible norms is our existence as a particular species—human beings. If we genuinely aim to design the world in ways that address the needs beyond just humans, we must become aware of our inherent human norms in our design work. This awareness requires us to expose these norms, making them visible so that we can work with them effectively. Currently, there are approaches that address these challenges separately: the more-thanhuman perspectives and norm-critical design. however, we lack a framework that successfully combines these two approaches. In our workshop, we aim to integrate these two perspectives, creating a unique take on design. We will build on an established critical methodological approach, allowing us to probe in depth our design practice (norm-critical design); yet bring a novel perspective in it, helping us identify, highlight and in turn discuss what human norms are we unknowingly drawing on in our design practice. While the scope of our workshop does not allow us to fundamentally change the "human norm," we contribute the crucial first step toward this goal: making human norms in our design work subject to critical examination.

RESEARCH BASIS FOR THE WORKSHOP

This workshop builds on the idea of integrating two existing design approaches: more-than-human and norm-critical design.

MORE-THAN-HUMAN DESIGN

The ongoing environmental crisis demands a fundamental shift in how we design our world. Historically, human-centered design has been the dominant approach to product development and innovation (Poikolainen Rosén, 2022). However, we are now confronting the limitations of this paradigm, which relies on unsustainable exploitation of natural resources and assumes infinite growth possibilities. We need to develop alternatives that extend beyond merely human needs. In our workshop, we term this alternative "morethan-human design"—an approach also known as "planet-centered design" (Vignoli et al., 2021), "livingcentered design," or related concepts.

Theoretically, this approach aligns with philosophical frameworks that emphasize post-anthropocentric thinking, such as posthuman feminism (Braidotti 2021) and the influential work of Haraway (Haraway 2007) and Tsing (Tsing 2017). Central to this approach is the focus on "designing for the **interdependent relationships** between humans, technologies and other organisms (such as animals, plants and microbes). This focus on interdependence forefronts that many organisms, including humans, benefit from considering design spaces as **holistic** and **relational** and implies that designers need to expand who or what counts as a user or stakeholder, who is included in design processes, and what is considered as design or designable." (x, Rosén, Salovaara, Botero & Juul Søndergaard 2024) Consequently, the "human" no longer occupies the central position; instead, the focus shifts to the complex, entangled relationships among diverse actors in our ecological systems.

NORM-CRITICAL DESIGN

Transforming the norms that strips other than-human agency off design processes call for norm-critical approaches. Giving way to marginalised perspectives can help convey biases and reconstruct knowledge that is more valid than when dominant perspectives claim to speak for them (Haraway, 2007). Norm critique can be thought of as a gear turning in a direction contrary to the interlocking gears that reproduce power, norms, and othering in any specific context (Nye et al. 2023). When incorporated in design practice as norm critical design approaches, it serves as a catalyst - facilitating a redirection of gaze, enabling problem reframing and changes in perspectives of human actors, including designers. Additionally, norm critical design can be used as a tool forcing us to move beyond theoretical and abstract debates and into tangible, actionable knowledge with practical implications, since the nature of design is concrete, direct, visual and/or material (Bardzell et al., 2012; Ehrnberger et al., 2017; Isaksson et al., 2017). By ideating and visualizing possible alternatives, normcritical speculation can serve as either discursive input, thus constituting tools to think through, or as solutions intended to disrupt norms through norm-creative design (Wikberg Nilsson & Jahnke, 2018).

Unconventional (norm-critical) design scenarios may provoke reflection and reassessment of existing values and related norms (Castillo et al., 2024; Kueh et al., 2022). This provocation depends on how well the design manages to highlight different voices and perspectives and make visible contextual norms, beliefs and subconscious values (Pangrazio, 2017). However, norm-critical design has traditionally been mostly engaged with socio-technical power relations and social sustainability. Revisiting Haraway's questions of *How to see? Where to see from? Whom to see with? Who gets to have more than one point of view? Who gets blinkered? Who wears blinkers? Who interprets the visual field?* (Haraway, 2007:120) may offer pathways

into where and how more than human actors can be brought into a design process.

SUMMARY

To sum up, current norm-critical design rarely explores the human-centered norm in design, but contains fruitful methods where more-than-human perspectives could be explored further. On the other hand, more-than-human design lacks a well established common framework, which would direct the specific steps in such explorations. In our workshop, we will work towards combining the two, creating a unique approach to design, which goes beyond the traditional critiques of human norms.

WORKSHOP PLAN

This workshop is a half-day activity (13:00-16:00), planned to be in-person but we will also provide a hybrid participation as an option. In this section, we will outline the practical steps for carrying out the workshop, ensuring a proper assessment of its feasibility and thorough preparation for its execution.

PRE-WORKSHOP ACTIVITY

Call for participation: The organizers will create and disseminate a website to attract and engage participants. The website will provide essential information, including the motivation for the workshop, a call for participation, an up-to-date schedule, and details about planned activities. Various channels will be used to distribute the website, including research mailing lists, social media platforms, and professional networks, ensuring broad outreach.

Case submission: Prior to the workshop, the participants will be invited to submit a case of interest, describing the human norms they identify in their work context. The case should describe the elements of: (1) a brief description of the context, (2) the human and non-human actors in the context, and (3) the identified human norm. Upon acceptance, participants need to bring an object to represent the identified norm. The examples of cases can include but are not limited to: human's relationship to plants, their biodiversity and plant care; traditional and modern engagement with water bodies and landscapes; urban housing and transportation for heterogeneous actors. However, cases also from other areas are welcome.

Review and synthesis: The organizers will review the submitted cases based on their relevance to the topic and diversity. The submitted cases will be synthesized into 3-4 major themes, allowing participants to choose a theme that appeals to them and form groups accordingly. The cases will be made available to the participants prior to the workshop; the participants will be given a specific task on how to approach the cases.

Preparation: The organizers will prepare a symbolic object for each theme to deepen the emotional and immersive connection. Additionally, a variety of prototyping materials - such as paper, pens, baking paper, plasticine, and toothpicks - will be provided to support the hands-on prototyping and creative expression. The organizers will prepare a Miro for easier onboarding into the workshop as well as for facilitating hybrid participation. The Miro will be available to the participants in a timely manner prior to the workshop.

A TENTATIVE PROGRAMME

The workshop will be organized into four phases, enabling active participation in the process of getting to know each other, shifting perspectives, making norm-critical prototypes, and sharing the experience and reflections. These four phases will be explained in detail in the tentative programme (Table 1).

Table 1: A tentative programme.

Phase & time	Activity
Phase 1: Creating shared ground 9:00 - 9:30	This phase focuses on creating a shared basis for our workshop. We will start by explaining the structure of the workshop, followed by participants' introductions, including the object they were asked to bring. This section will also include two mini-keynotes on more-than-human design and norm-critical design to create a shared critical ground.
Phase 2: Analysis and shifting perspectives 9:30 - 10:30	Prior to the workshop, we will generate themes from participants' submissions. During this workshop phase, we will present them to the participants. We will discuss together the different human norms in the contexts described in the participants' cases. We will finish our discussions by identifying possible specific scenarios, in which we would be able to shift from human to more-than-human perspectives. This part will build on scaffolding activities which will enable the participants to explore the possibilities and limits of shifting perspectives, such as mediation. Including a break.
Phase 3: Making norm-critical prototypes 10:30 - 11:30	Following the norm-critical methodology, based on Phase 2, we will aim to create several norm-critical prototypes. These low-fidelity prototypes should capture the combination of the identified human

	norms and more-than-human perspectives. This is a key step, as it should help us further understand both the human norm but also the integration of the two approaches.
Phase 4: A sharing circle 11:30 - 12:00	Finally, we share our experiences with each other from the day and reflect over our learnings from the day. Next steps will be discussed, including development of the low-fidelity prototype.

INTENDED PARTICIPANTS

The workshop aims to engage 4 to 12 participants. The organizers welcome scholars from different backgrounds, including design, human-computer interaction, sociology, and humanities, to inspire an interdisciplinary endeavour to explore human norms from more-than-human perspectives.

AFTER-WORKSHOP ACTIVITY

After the workshop, we will keep the Miro accessible to the participants, and collect their written learnings from the day, allowing for deeper reflections around the workshop activities. At the end, we will prompt our participants to further develop their prototypes and share with us and each other what they could learn further on.

ETHICAL CONSIDERATION

We will align ourselves with the formal ethical requirements, ensuring that no sensitive personal information is requested. As we will have access to participants' names and email addresses, these will be used solely for workshop-related purposes. Additionally, we will take a situated point of view on ethical issues during the workshop, as it will depend on which narratives the participants will bring. We will make sure that the workshop activities do not cause harm to participants or more-than-human actors.

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